

HINDUSTAN TIMES

KAMALJEET SEHRAWAT, *51* ▶

| BJP | *West Delhi*

Modi *hai toh mumkin hai*," Sehrawat had told reporters then, adding that she had learnt about her nomination on television. The first woman to head the South Delhi Municipal Corporation (2017-19) and a fervent women's rights campaigner, she was replacing local bigwig Parvesh Verma, sitting MP and son of the late CM Sahib Singh Verma. She repaid the faith in spades, defeating veteran ex-Congressman and AAP candidate Mahabal Mishra by nearly 200,000 votes.

▶ KAMLESH JANGDE, *46*

| BJP | *Janjgir-Champa (SC), Chhattisgarh*

Denied a ticket in 2019, Kamlesh replaced sitting MP Gujharam Ajgalley and went on to win the seat by 60,000 votes. Hailing from the state's biggest Dalit community, the Satnamis, Kamlesh is a postgraduate in Hindi Literature. She cut her teeth in politics with the ABVP in 2002, and was sarpanch of her village Masaniya Kalan twice between 2005 and 2015. She also served as president of the BJP Mahila Morcha in her native Sakti district.



RAJWANT RAWAT

▼ PRATIBHA DHANORKAR, *38*

| CONGRESS | *Chandrapur, Maharashtra*

Among the Congress ruins in the 2019 Lok Sabha election, a lone candidate kept the party flag flying in the state. That was Pratibha's husband Suresh Dhanorkar, who won from the coal and forest belt of Chandrapur. Unfortunately, the ex-Shiv Sainik passed away in 2023 and it fell on his widow and Warora MLA to keep the family legacy going. The Dhanorkars are quite an influential family in the region, and said to have a stake in the liquor trade in Chandrapur. The polarisation among the Kunbis (peasant community) also worked in Pratibha's favour, helping her trounce a BJP biggie: forest minister Sudhir Mungantiwar.





SMITA WAGH, *56* ▶

| BJP | *Jalgaon, Maharashtra*

A resident of Amalner, Smita has risen through the ranks, starting with the RSS student body ABVP, where she played an active role in the protests for the North Maharashtra University. Her father was chairman of the panchayat samiti, and she started working for the BJP in the 1990s. Wagh had a term in the Maharashtra legislative council and was also the state general secretary. A contender for the Jalgaon seat in 2019 too, she was dropped in favour of Unmesh Patil. However, this time, the BJP chose Wagh over Patil, who sulked and joined the Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray). Patil's associate Karan Pawar contested against Wagh as an SS(UBT) nominee, but lost by nearly 250,000 votes.



– Jumana Shah, Rahul Noronha, Amarnath K. Menon, Avishek G. Dastidar and Dhaval S. Kulkarni